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Project 4: Artist Statement

This quarter, I felt very satisfied with my projects and like they were able to engage with the readings well. I enjoyed exploring themes of accessibility and authority with my work. A project I created that didn't feel quite as whole as my others was Project 2. The piece was essentially a poem generator where the user could determine if the generated string of words was meaningful or not. I enjoyed this concept and felt it captured my engagement with Travesty Generator and The Policeman's Beard is Half Constructed. With these pieces, I felt like it was the people involved (the users and creators) who dictated how meaningful a piece generated by an algorithm was. After submitting the project, I realized how much more interesting it would be for the program to determine the meaning and significance of its own work.

One of the chapters I read from the New Media Poetics reading was chapter 7; the chapter begins with the idea of electronic poetry:

"...digital poetry today may seem to fetishize digital presentation as something in itself remarkable, as if to say, "Look what the computer can do!" But no medium or technique of production can in itself give the poet (or any other kind of artist) the inspiration or imagination to produce works of art." (Perloff 143).

This statement struck me because that's exactly what the point of *The Policeman's Beard Is Half Constructed* is, and similarly, my project 2.

After reading the chapter, I decided I wanted to explore the tension between user choice and system constraint. In the chapter, Perloff argues that claims about user interactivity in digital texts are often limited because the choices are ultimately preprogrammed by the author. This theme worked well with an idea I had after submitting the original project. I thought it would be more compelling if the program could 'doubt' the users. With my original project, I gave the users complete authority over the meaning of a poem, but I think it would be interesting if I took that authority away (similarly in a previous project where I changed a user's input as they typed on the page).

My completed project still functions similarly to the original. When the user first loads the page, they are given a single word; from there, the user determines whether that word is meaningful or nonsense. If the user chooses "meaningful", a new randomly generated word appears beside the original word, and the user is prompted to determine again whether the new sequence of words has meaning or is nonsense. With each iteration where the user determines meaning, a number in the corner meant to keep score will increment by 1.

If the user were to determine the sequence of words to be nonsense at any point, the sequence of words would clear and be replaced by a new randomly generated word for the user to begin the process again of choosing meaningful or nonsense.

The main new feature is that there is a 30% chance that the program will doubt your "nonsense" decision. The user is met with a pop-up window asking, "Are you sure?" The user can close the message but is immediately greeted by a new pop-up window continuing to doubt the user's decision. After the first sign of doubt, the user's authority is immediately revoked. No

matter how many times the user exits the pop-up, a new one will appear. Reloading the page does little to help; the page is stuck, and the user needs to completely exit the program. The user is given the illusion of choice, but at some point in the experience, the program will inevitably doubt the user's judgment.

Another feature I added was displaying the discarded poems in the background of the page. I was inspired by feedback I received on the original project that pointed out how it would be nice to keep the poems that were meaningful before it was determined that they were nonsense. I think a twist on this idea would be interesting, though. In this revision, the user is confronted with the poems they think are nonsense, which will ultimately lead to the program's last straw.